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# General Knowledge
# Modern History

## STUDY NOTES

### Expansion of British East India Company - Anglo-Afghan Wars

# Anglo-Afghan Wars (1839-1919)

The Anglo-Afghan Wars were a series of three conflicts between British India and Afghanistan, fought over the control and influence of Afghanistan as a buffer state to prevent Russian expansion towards India.

## Background

- **The Great Game:** Rivalry between the British and Russian empires for control over Central Asia in the 19th century.
- **Afghanistan's Strategic Importance:** Afghanistan's position between British India and the expanding Russian Empire made it a key buffer state.
- **British Objectives:** The British aimed to establish influence over Afghanistan to prevent Russian advancements towards India.

### First Anglo-Afghan War (1839-1842)

#### Timeline

| Date | Event |
|---|---|
| 1839 | British invade Afghanistan, capture Kabul |
| 1840 | Deposition of Dost Mohammad; Shah Shuja installed as ruler |
| 1841 | Afghan uprising in Kabul |
| January 1842 | British retreat from Kabul, disastrous losses |
| October 1842 | British retake Kabul, eventually withdraw |

## Key Points

- Cause: British fear of Russian influence in Afghanistan.
- British Occupation: British installed a puppet ruler, Shah Shuja, but faced resistance from Afghans.
- Outcome: British defeat; retreat from Kabul was one of the worst defeats, with only one survivor of the main army.

## Second Anglo-Afghan War (1878-1880)

### Timeline

| Date | Event |
|---|---|
| 1878 | British forces enter Afghanistan after the Afghan ruler, Sher Ali, aligns with Russia |
| September 1879 | Treaty of Gandamak signed; Amir Yakub Khan installed |
| 1879 | British Resident Sir Louis Cavagnari killed, uprising follows |
| 1879-1880 | Battles of Charasiab, Ahmed Khel – British victories |
| September 1880 | Battle of Maiwand – Afghan victory |
| 1880 | Battle of Kandahar – British victory; end of war |

- **Cause**: Renewed Russian influence in Afghanistan; British wanted a pro-British ruler.
- **Major Battles:** Charasiab, Ahmed Khel, Maiwand, Kandahar.
- **Outcome:** Treaty of Gandamak; British control over Afghanistan's foreign policy, Afghanistan remains a buffer state.

## Third Anglo-Afghan War (1919)

### Timeline

| Date | Event |
|---|---|
| **May 1919** | Afghanistan declares war on British India |

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| | |
|---|---|
| **May-June 1919** | Battles of Khyber Pass; British air raids |
| **August 1919** | Treaty of Rawalpindi signed; Afghanistan gains independence |

## Key Points

- **Cause**: Afghanistan, under King Amanullah, sought full independence following World War I.
- **Outcome:** Treaty of Rawalpindi; Afghanistan gains control over foreign affairs, marking the end of British influence

## Takeaways

- **Geopolitical Tensions**: The wars were part of the Great Game between British and Russian Empires.
- **Afghan Resilience:** Each war highlighted Afghanistan's strong resistance to foreign intervention.
- **Impact on British Policy:** The British finally recognized Afghanistan's independence post-1919, marking the end of direct British involvement.

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